The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP

Donald Trump said America may hit Kharg Island, the site of **Iran's** main oil-export terminal, "a few more times just for fun", after strikes "totally demolished" most of the island. He earlier said America had exclusively struck military targets and left the island's oil infrastructure intact. Mr Trump also called on countries to send warships to the Strait of Hormuz in response to Iran's de facto closure of the waterway.

Meanwhile Iran fired six missile salvos at **Israel** on Saturday. Most appear to have been shot down by interceptors; a man and a teenage boy were injured in the southern city of Eilat. And **Lebanese** authorities accused Israel of killing 12 medics when its missiles hit a clinic in the south of the country. On a visit to Beirut, António Guterres, the UN's secretary-general, called for a ceasefire.

Asif Ali Zardari, the president of **Pakistan**, said that **Afghanistan**'s government had "crossed a red line" and "brought grave consequences upon itself" when it launched drones against civilian areas of Pakistan on Friday. The drones were intercepted but debris wounded locals. The clashes are the latest in a conflict that began last month in relation to what Pakistan describes as Afghan support for the Pakistani Taliban, a group of Islamist militants.

Five people were arrested in **Cuba** after a Communist Party building was vandalised following a rally. Rare displays of public dissent have broken out in protest against spiralling food prices and power cuts, which are becoming longer and more unpredictable. Divisions are widening in Cuba as the oil embargo imposed by the United States in January bites.

Bobi Wine, a popular Ugandan opposition leader who went into hiding after a disputed presidential election in January, confirmed that he had managed to leave the country. He was the subject of vile threats by Muhoozi Kainerugaba, who is the army chief and son of the long-serving president, Yoweri Museveni. Mr Wine said in a video, “At the right time I will come back and continue with the cause.”

North Korea fired what appeared to be around ten missiles into the Sea of Japan as **America** and **South Korea** carried out joint military exercises, which they claim are defensive. On Friday South Korea’s prime minister, Kim Min-seok, met Mr Trump in Washington to discuss ways to resume talks with the North, which were paused in 2019.

Jürgen Habermas, the German philosopher behind the concept of the “public sphere”, died aged 96. Mr Habermas came to prominence in the 1950s, as Germany rebuilt itself and its politics after Nazism. He eagerly participated in public debates and was not shy about criticising politicians. He argued for greater European integration to counter nationalism, which he saw as dangerous.

Word of the week: Tilly tax, guild royalties paid by film studios for using AI-generated actors. Ahead of the Oscars, read what nobody at the Hollywood bash wants you to know.

Photograph: Getty Images

France heads to the polls

France votes in the first round of mayoral elections on Sunday. For some cities, including Paris, the race looks tight. The capital has been held by socialists for 25 years. Polls suggest a close contest between two front-runners: Emmanuel Grégoire, a socialist, and Rachida Dati, on the centre-right. The outcome will largely depend on whether candidates who qualify for the second-round vote on March 22nd withdraw in favour of a tactical alliance with a better-placed contender.

Marine Le Pen's populist-right National Rally and its friends have their eyes on the town hall in Nice. Their candidate there, Eric Ciotti, who defected from the centre-right, is trying to dethrone Christian Estrosi, an ally of Emmanuel Macron's centrists. The president's party, which has never put down strong local roots, looks set to struggle. Edouard Philippe, a former prime minister and mayor of Le Havre, could also face difficulties. If he is not re-elected, he has suggested he will not stand for the presidency in 2027.

Photograph: Getty Images

A new Kazakhstan?

On Sunday Kazakhstan will vote in a referendum on sweeping changes to its constitution, which include shrinking the parliament. Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, the president, says they will improve checks and balances in the authoritarian country. Critics warn that it may have the opposite effect. They fear Mr Tokayev may argue that resetting the constitution should also reset the term limits of serving presidents—a loophole favoured by several Central Asian autocrats and Russia's Vladimir Putin.

Mr Tokayev has promised to leave office in 2029, in accordance with the single-term limit he introduced in 2022 to prevent political power grabs. His predecessor, Nursultan Nazarbayev, ruled for three decades, before handing over to Mr Tokayev in a choreographed succession in 2019. Mr Tokayev later promised to do away with such "super-presidential" powers, and cracked down on some of Mr Nazarbayev's cronies for their extraordinary wealth. That will be seen as gross hypocrisy if he uses the new constitution to cling to power instead.

Photograph: Getty Images

Is a nuclear-energy renaissance under way?

The energy crisis in the Gulf is reviving interest in nuclear power. Since the Iran war began Brazil, Belgium, Britain, China, Italy and South Korea have all made new commitments to increase nuclear capacity. Existing plans in France and Japan have gained momentum. India agreed to buy 11,000 tons of uranium from Canada for $1.9bn, the largest such deal ever. America approved its first advanced nuclear reactor.

It is not the first time volatile energy markets have given nuclear a boost. Worldwide fuel shortages, caused by Arab states' oil embargo in 1973 and the Iranian revolution in 1979, also drove investment into nuclear energy. By 1996 nuclear power was generating 17.5% of all electricity. But that share has been decreasing steadily since, mostly because of high-profile disasters and high capital costs. The need to limit global warming by slashing greenhouse-gas emissions has never been powerful enough to reverse that trend. An energy panic may have changed the calculus.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Winter Paralympics has a climate problem

For the organisers of the Winter Paralympics, which concludes in Cortina, Italy, on Sunday, the past fortnight has been anything but smooth. For the first time since it invaded Ukraine in 2022, Russia was permitted to send a team and fly its flag at a major global sporting event. The silence that greeted its athletes at the opening ceremony showed the decision was far from popular. Ukraine and 15 other countries boycotted the event. Meanwhile, Iran's sole winter Paralympian, Aboulfazl Khatibi, was unable to travel.

The difficulties did not end there. Unseasonably warm weather left snowboarders and skiers navigating slushy courses, elevating the risk of injury and impairing performance. "I don't believe that the Paralympics should be happening right now," concluded Amy Purdy, an American snowboarder. As winters become milder, pressure to bring the Winter Paralympics forward to January or February, or merge it with the Olympics, will only intensify.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of the week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Carlos Flexa Ribeiro, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

Jan Redeby, Maseru, Lesotho

Enzo Orsini, Naples, Florida

They all gave the correct answers of: Licence to Kill, The Painted Veil, Cake by the Ocean, groom and ring. The theme is a wedding, where the couple needs a licence, the bride sometimes wears a veil, everyone eats cake and the groom and bride exchange rings.

The questions were:

Monday: Which was the second and last Bond film to feature Timothy Dalton?

Tuesday: Which William Somerset Maugham novel features a cholera epidemic in China?

Wednesday: What was the biggest hit by DNCE, a rock band whose lead singer was Joe Jonas?

Thursday: What is another term for someone who works as a stable hand?

Friday: Which word links the venues for a circus performance and a boxing match?

We know not through our intellect, but through our experience.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty